

Q What should we buy for our baby to sleep in?

Your baby will need a bassinet or a crib for sleeping in. Another increasingly popular option is to opt for a co-sleeping crib which attaches to your bed, or you could try a “baby nest.”

Although you can use a full-sized crib from the beginning, a newborn may feel cosier in a bassinet or crib for the first few weeks, since it more closely mimics the feeling of being cocooned in the uterus. A bassinet is also easy to use as a travel crib or move around from room to room so your baby can be in the same room as you for all his sleep time, both day and night.

Some cribs are designed to be gently rocked to soothe a baby; they last longer than bassinets because they are bigger and so a baby can sleep in them longer, but they are less transportable. A co-sleeping crib attached to your bed is great if you want to have your baby near you but not actually in your bed. The crib sits alongside your bed with a drop-down side so you can easily reach over to comfort your baby or get him for breast-feeding without having to get out of bed. Make sure there is no gap between the crib and your bed that your baby could fall into. Another option is a baby nest, a baby mattress with sturdy sides placed in your bed, that gives your baby his own dedicated sleeping space safe from hazards such as pillows or duvets. When you do come to choose a full-size crib, make sure it conforms to all health and safety standards (right).

A bassinet or crib closely mimics the feeling of being cocooned in the uterus, so is ideal in the first few weeks.

SLEEPING OPTIONS

It's personal preference as to which type of crib or crib you choose, but make sure they fit these criteria.



» **Bassinet:** choose one with a sturdy base and handles so that it's secure when you move it around. Babies can grow out of bassinets quite quickly, and you may find that at around two to three months your baby is looking a little cramped. She should be able to sleep with her arms out to the side, or flung up by her head, without touching the sides or top of the basket.



» **Full-size crib:** make sure the crib conforms to the US Consumer Product Safety Commission's federal requirements, as of June, 2011. Don't use a secondhand crib. Drop-side cribs are no longer sold or manufactured and crib slats are stronger to prevent breakage. Slats must be no more than 2½ inches apart, so babies can't get stuck. Some have an adjustable mattress that can be lowered as your baby grows.



Did you know...

Your newborn will be too young to play with toys, but he will be stimulated by his surroundings early on. Young babies can't focus far, but they enjoy looking at black-and-white patterns, high-contrast colors, and baby mirrors. Your baby will also enjoy watching a colorful mobile hung above his crib. Make sure this is secure and out of his reach. Some mobiles have a wind-up music box attached, which babies can find very soothing, or you could place a music box in the room. Young babies love to touch, so find a couple of first soft books with different textures for him to explore.

Q What bedding does my baby need in his bassinet or crib?

You need one or two mattress protectors if his diaper leaks at night and three or four sheets, so you have spare bedding as items are washed.

Choose fitted cotton sheets because they stay in place. A lightweight baby sleep sack is better than a blanket for keeping your baby warm. Loose blankets aren't allowed, but a thin one is okay if you place your baby's feet at the crib's bottom. Tuck the blanket securely under the mattress's bottom and sides. Cover the baby only to chest height. Babies' hands and feet often feel colder than the rest of their body, so are not a reliable measure of their temperature. Feel the nape of his neck, or chest, to gauge his temperature as he sleeps, and adjust the bedding as necessary.

Q Are there any must-have items of furniture for the baby we should invest in other than a crib?

Since you will be spending a fair amount of time nursing, comforting, and perhaps reading to your baby, a chair is a worthwhile addition.

Chairs marketed for feeding your baby are available, although these can be pricey. Whatever chair you choose, make sure it is comfortable for you with good back and arm support, and that you can place your feet flat on the floor. Dedicated changing tables are also handy and come in a variety of designs with shelves, drawers, and cupboard space though, again, these can be costly. Alternatively, a chest of drawers large enough to put a changing mat and some diapers on top is just as good, and good storage is essential in a nursery.